

Gauff (US Open). Despite this seeming parity, Świątek deserves this accolade over Sabalenka. Besides winning her third French Open, the 22-year-old Pole captured the WTA Finals (the fifth most important tournament), the Qatar TotalEnergies Open, the China Open, both 1000 events, and the Warsaw Open. Showing a high level of consistency, Iga reached the finals at Madrid, Dubai, and Stuttgart, along with the semifinals at Indian Wells, Montreal, and Cincinnati. Sabalenka, who finally overcame the nerves that plagued her shaky serve, finished a strong second. The power-hitting Belarusian captured her first major at Melbourne, made the final at the US Open, Indian Wells, and Stuttgart, and also grabbed titles at Madrid and Adelaide.

BEST MEN'S MATCH

Revenge was on Djokovic's mind when he faced his biggest rival of the present era, World No. 1 Carlos Alcaraz, in the Cincinnati final, five weeks after the sensational Spaniard dethroned him at Wimbledon. In a match where experience barely prevailed over youth, Djokovic, 36, had to stave off a match point to surmount Alcaraz, 20, in a thriller that lasted 3 hours, 49 minutes in sweltering conditions that touched 90° F. This was also the longest best-of-three-set final in ATP tour history, since 1990, and finished 5-7, 7-6 (7), 7-6 (4). "This was one of the most exciting matches I've ever played in any tournament. It felt like a Grand Slam," said an ecstatic Djokovic, who ripped off his shirt to celebrate, a gesture he typically reserves for a major final.

BEST WOMEN'S MATCH

The Australian Open final resembled a heavyweight title fight, with two sluggers trading heavy punches for 12 rounds. Fifth-seeded Sabalenka exorcised the ghosts of AO 2022 — when she averaged more than 12 double faults a match and was ousted in the fourth round — to overcome reigning Wimbledon champion Elena Rybakina 4-6, 6-3, 6-4. The



Dream run: Besides the winning her third French Open, Iga Świątek captured the WTA Finals (the fifth most important tournament), the Qatar TotalEnergies Open, and the China Open, both 1000 events, and the Warsaw Open. AFP